This is not a new idea; it has been known since *The Republic* by Plato, which is 380 BC. Direct democracy does not work well. Taking policy questions to individuals, through referendums, does not work well, as individuals lack the incentive to invest in knowledge about public policy choices.

There is a lot of unhappiness that the voters in the UK or Italy chose the wrong option in the referendums of 2016. But we should not be surprised when referendums fail to give good outcomes. The Constitution of India may not have won a referendum either in 1950 or today. Similarly, demonetization was shown to be reasonably popular in opinion polls in early 2017.

> *The fact of having the majority on one's side does not in any way prove that one must be right. Indeed, humanity has always advanced through the initiative and efforts of individuals and minorities, whereas the majority, by its very nature, is slow, conservative, submissive to superior force and to established privileges.*
>
> Enrico Malatesta

Direct democracy also suffers from majoritarianism, the idea that policy should be made based on the views of 51 per cent of the population. We must question the extent to which 'the voice of the people' is the oracle that must be followed. There is much more to liberal democracy than winning elections.

The limits of voting systems

The great economist Kenneth Arrow proved an 'impossibility theorem', which shows that voting systems are not able to consistently aggregate the preferences of voters. [5] Specifically, Arrow defined three sensible criteria that a reasonable voting system ought to simultaneously satisfy, and proved that no voting system could achieve all the three at the same time. This emphasizes how voting and elections are less useful than meets the eye, in finding the right pathways for policy.